Popovers

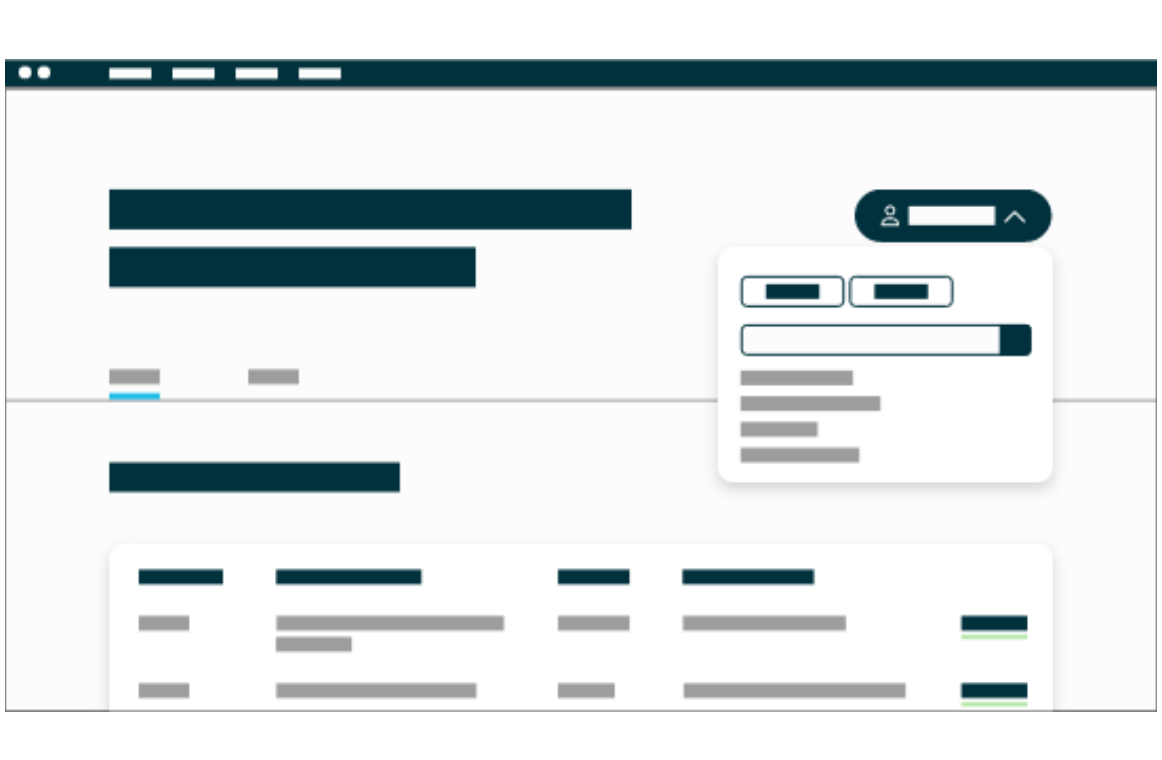
A popover is layer that appears above other content onscreen when people click or tap a control or interactive area.

Overview

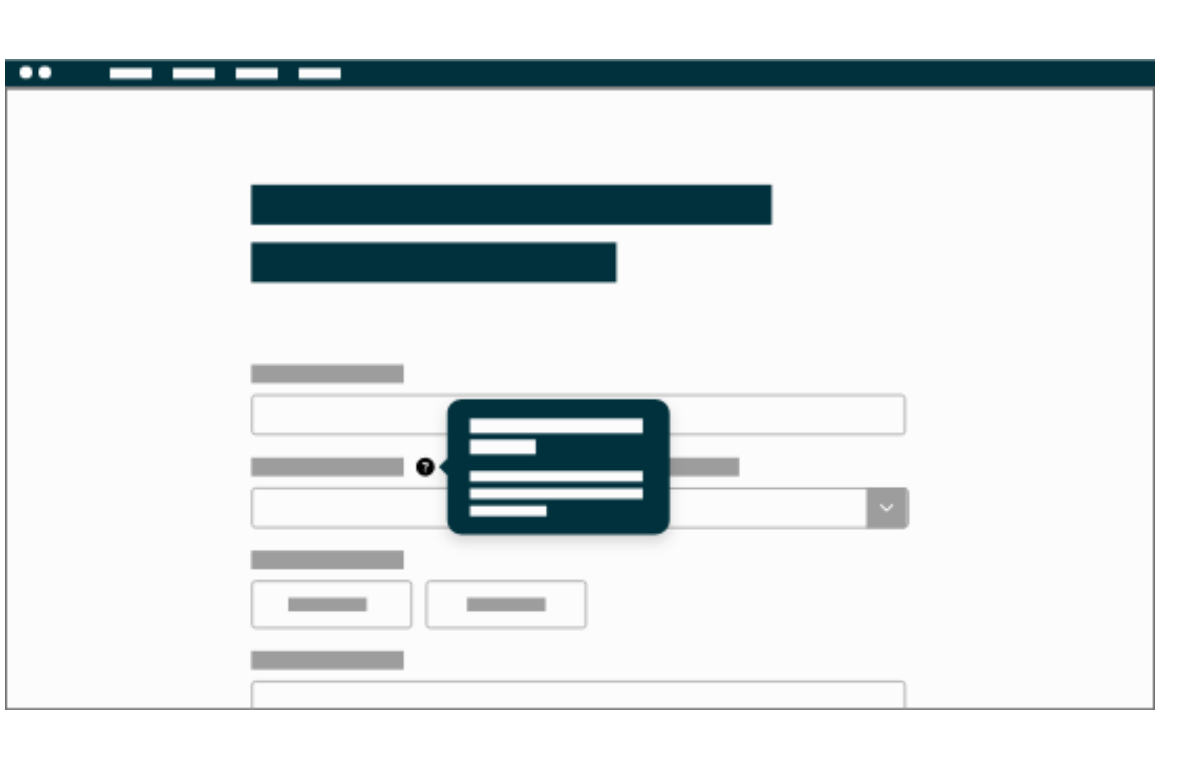
Popovers are visually discreet and unobtrusive elements commonly used in user interfaces to provide a more focused and intuitive experience by presenting relevant information or options in a compact and easily dismissible manner. It provides extra options or details without interrupting the user workflow. Only one popover can appear at a time and can contain varying text and interactive elements.

✓ How to use	✕ How not to use
Use popovers for non-critical information: Popovers are intended to provide additional contextual information or options related to a specific element.	**Don't use overlays with popovers:** Overlays disable the page and prevent users from performing other task. If you are displaying critical information, consider using a modal instead.
Make popovers clear and concise: Avoid large amounts of text, it can overload the user with irrelevant information and mobile users can lose visibility of the page.	**Don't cover attributed elements:** Try to avoid the popover covering the element the popover is attributed to as it will lose context, e.g. headings, form labels.
Keep popovers in view until dismissed: Dismissal methods may vary, users may click the UI trigger again, click the surrounding area around the popover or dismiss it directly with an 'X' button.	

Popover variants



Menu



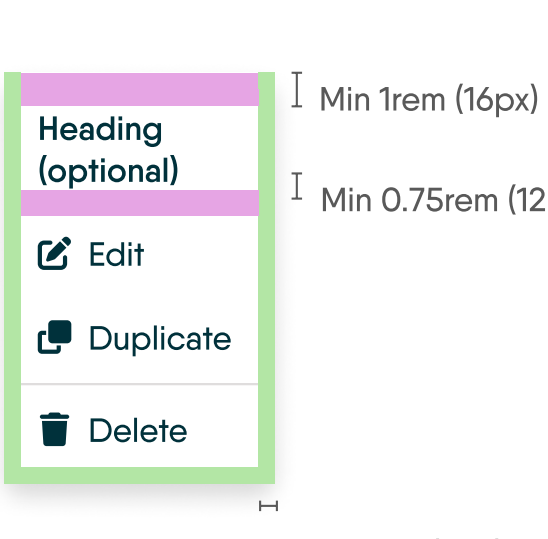
Pointer

Variant	Usage
No tip	When a trigger button has a visually defined down state or active state, such as a distinct visual change (e.g. colour change, shading, or indentation) when it is pressed or activated, the popover that appears may not require an additional arrow-like tip to indicate its association with the button.
Pointer	Popovers with a pointer tip should be used to help show the relationship between the popover and where it was triggered from.

Dimensions

Padding

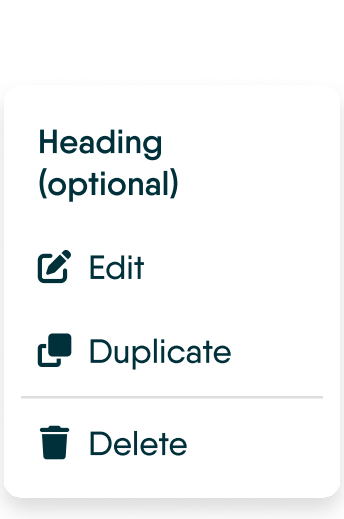
The default popover should contain a minimum of 0.5rem (8px) internal padding.


Heading (optional)
Edit
Duplicate
Delete
Min 1rem (16px)
Min 0.75rem (12px)
Min 0.5rem (8px)

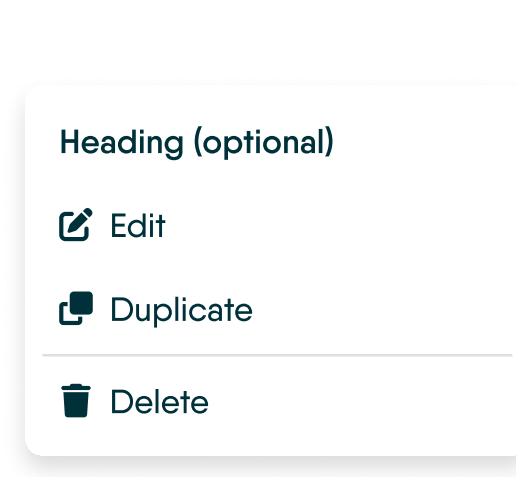
Width

Fixed

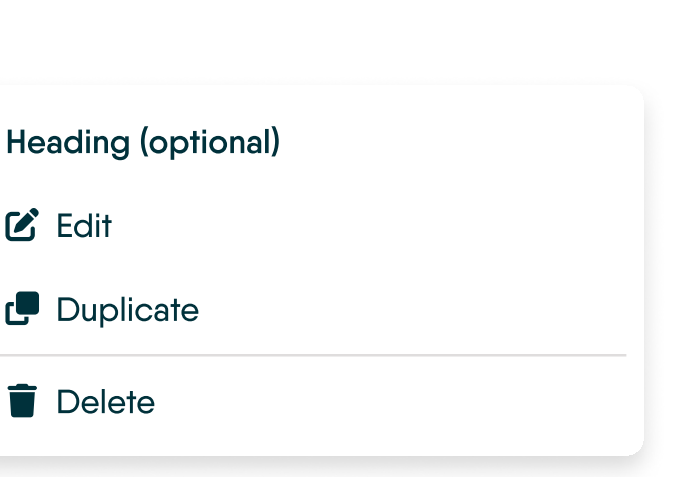
We can apply a fixed width to popovers using columns. There are 3 fixed sizes, small: 10rem (160px), medium: 15rem (240px), and large: 20rem (320px).


Heading (optional)
Edit
Duplicate
Delete

Small: 10rem (160px)


Heading (optional)
Edit
Duplicate
Delete

Medium: 15rem (240px)

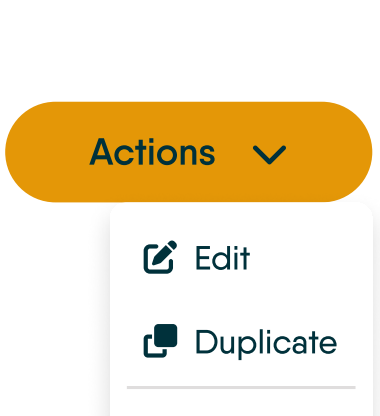

Heading (optional)
Edit
Duplicate
Delete

Large: 20rem (320px)

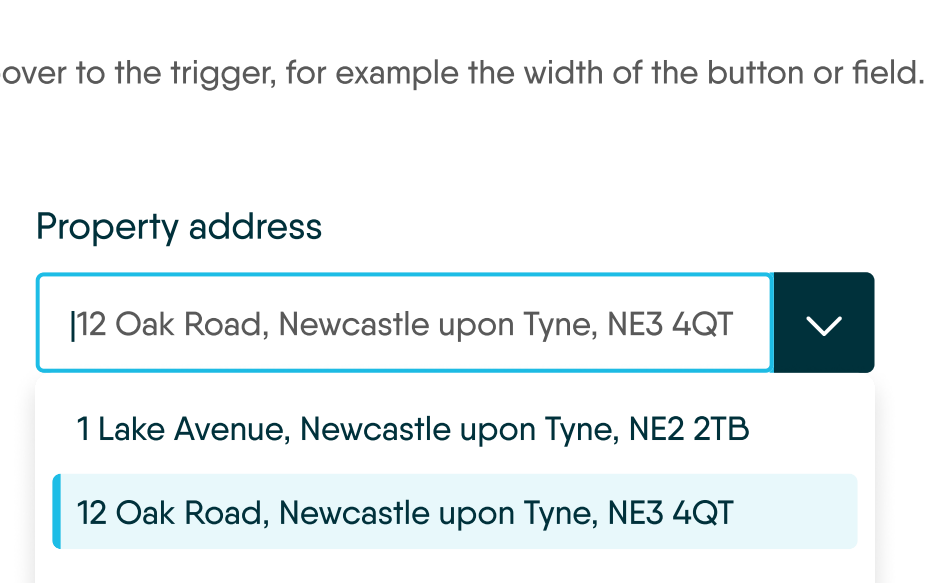
Fluid

Instead of a fixed width we can apply 2 fluid width options to the popover, hug and fill.

- Hug will hug the contents of the popover and make the popover the width of the widest content in the popover.
- Fill will match the width of the popover to the trigger, for example the width of the button or field.


Actions
Edit
Duplicate
Delete

Hug - Popover hugs the content within it

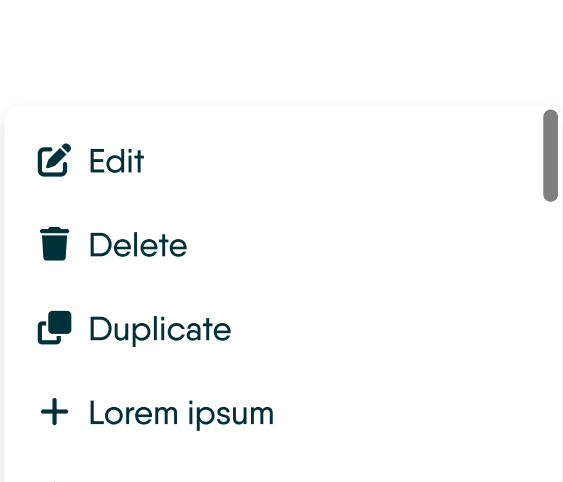

Property address
12 Oak Road, Newcastle upon Tyne, NE3 4QT
1 Lake Avenue, Newcastle upon Tyne, NE2 2TB
12 Oak Road, Newcastle upon Tyne, NE3 4QT
3 Peach Avenue, Newcastle upon Tyne, NE1 1PO

Fill - Popover's width matches the trigger for the menu

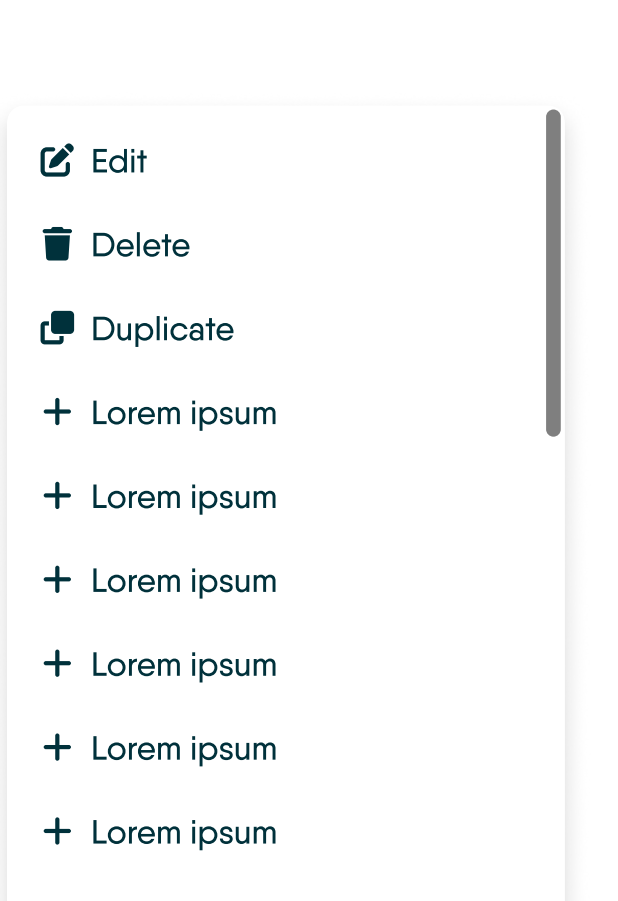
Height

Fixed

We can apply a fixed height to popovers. There are 2 fixed sizes, small (12.5rem) and medium (25rem). We can either chose to use one of the fixed heights or apply a calculation to the menu to work out which of the sizes is most appropriate depending upon the spacing available.


Edit
Delete
Duplicate
Lorem ipsum
Lorem ipsum

Small: 12.5rem (200px)


Edit
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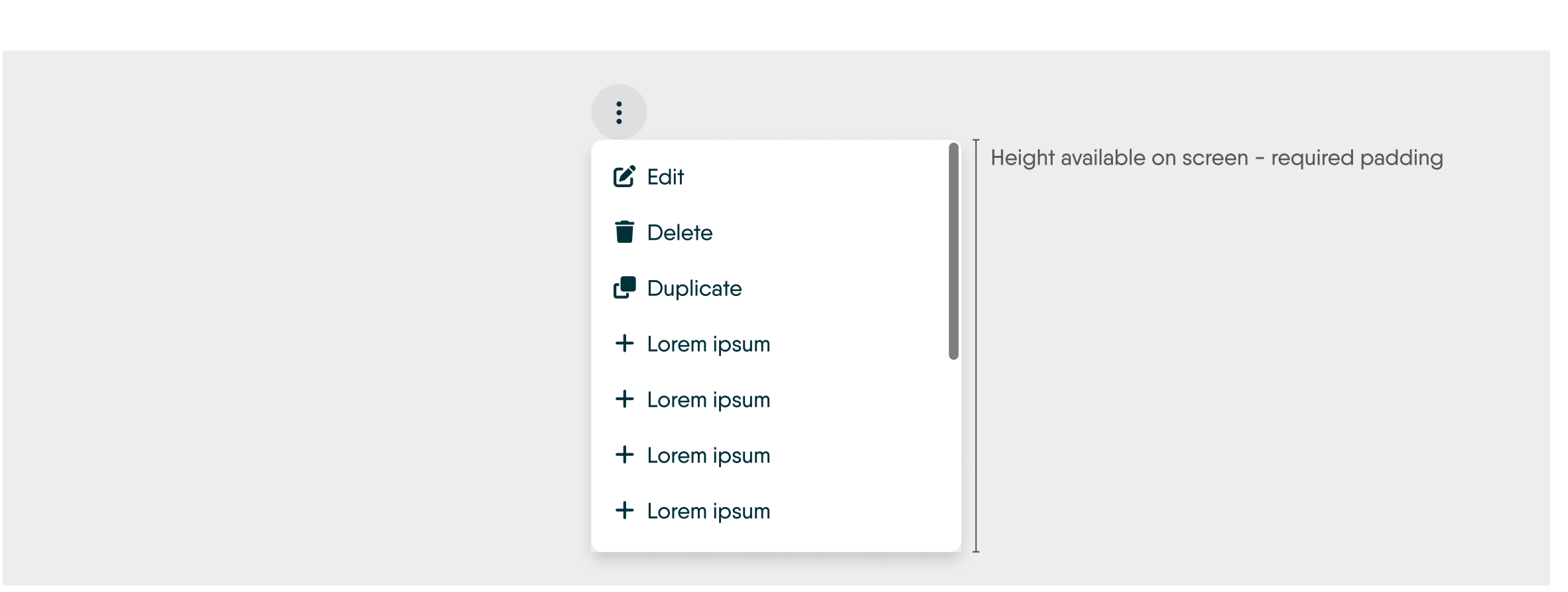
Large: 25rem (400px)

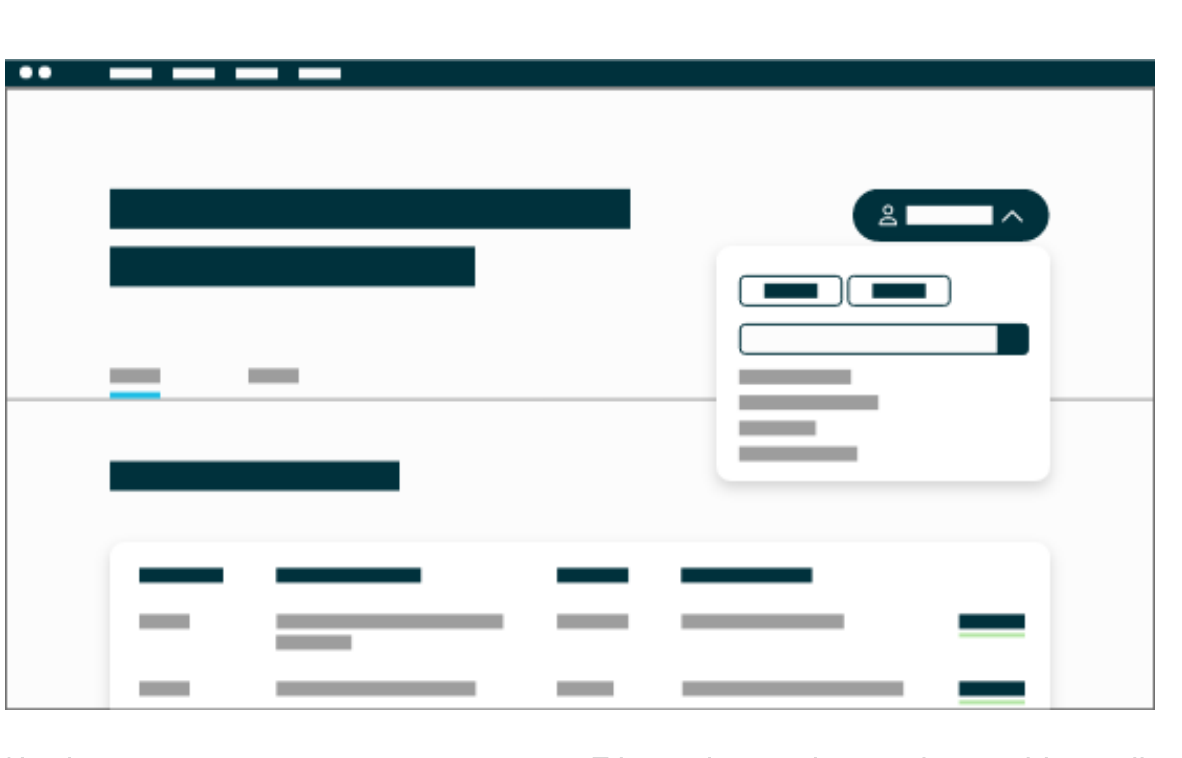
Fluid

We can apply a fluid height to popovers. Fluid heights calculate the height of the popover by determining how much screen space is available above or below the popover (also taking into account any required spacing) then produces a popover which makes use of all the height available.


Edit
Delete
Duplicate
Lorem ipsum
Lorem ipsum
Lorem ipsum
Lorem ipsum
Height available on screen – required padding

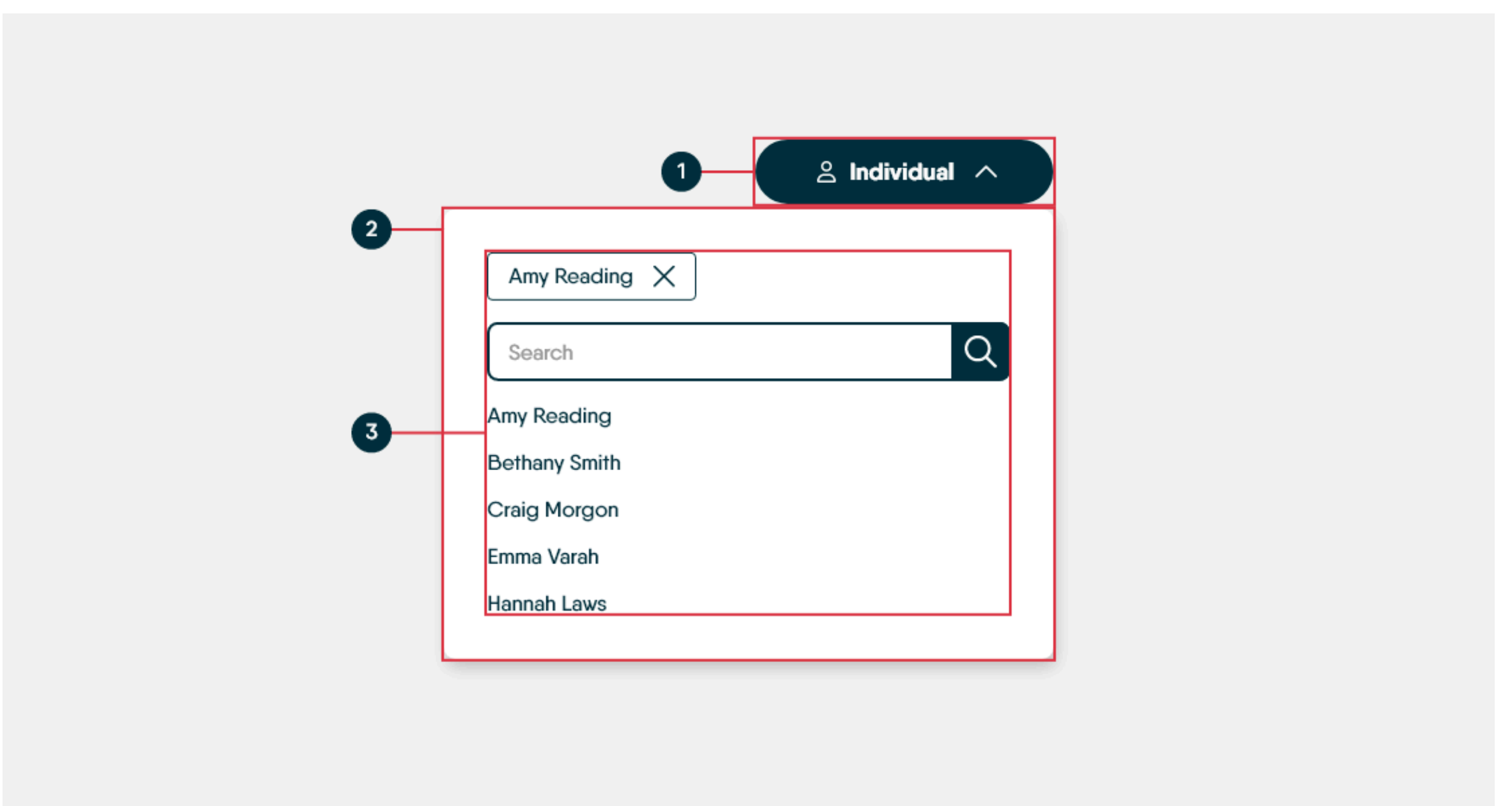
No tip

No tip popovers have a trigger button that has a visually defined down state or active state. They align with the trigger button and don't need a pointer to define their relationship to the trigger button. They are designed to be visually discreet and unobtrusive, allowing the main content and trigger element to remain prominent.



No tip popover amongst page content. Trigger button is prominent without distracting from main page content.

Anatomy


1
2
3
Individual
Amy Reading
Search
Amy Reading
Bethany Smith
Craig Morgan
Emma Varah
Hannah Laws

1. UI trigger button
2. Container
3. Body: contains the content, could include text, links, icons, etc.

Trigger

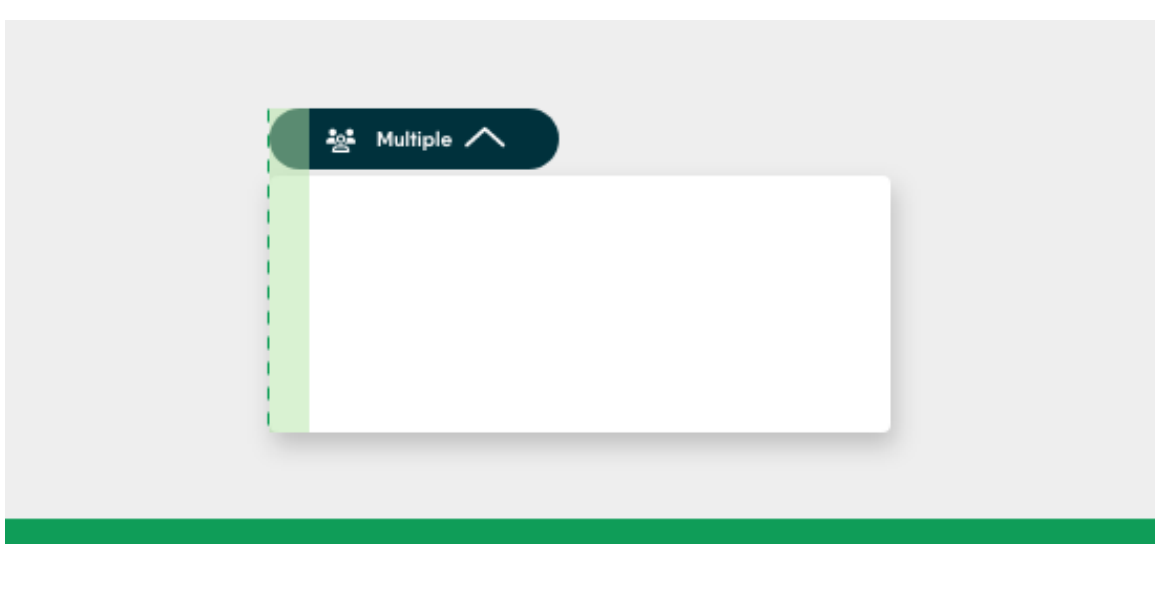
No tip popovers can be triggered by clicking the UI trigger (button).

Dismissal

Pop ups can be dismissed in a variety of ways, depending on how it is built and its use case.

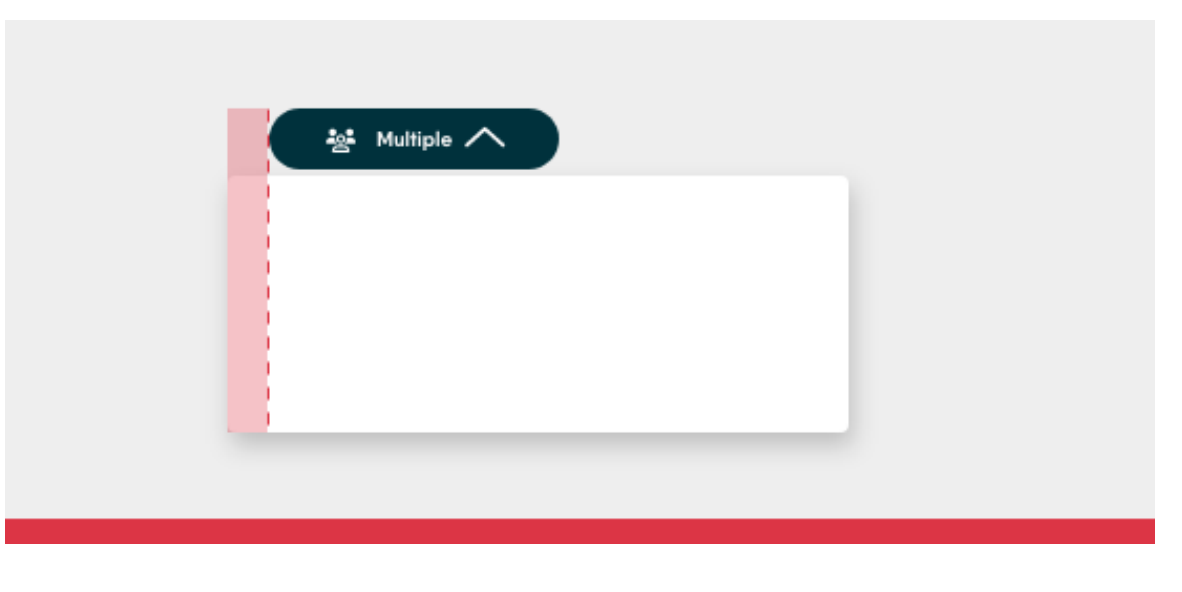
UI trigger: Clicking the UI trigger (button)
Mouse leave: Moving the mouse away from the popover container
Scroll depth: Scrolling more than a specified distance on screen
Scroll out of view: Scrolling the popover out of view
Outside Click: Clicking outside the pop-up area
Escape Key: Allowing users to dismiss the popover by pressing the escape (Esc) key is a common convention. This is especially useful for keyboard-centric users who prefer to navigate without using a mouse.
User Interaction: popovers may also be designed to be dismissed when users interact with specific elements within the pop-up. For example, if a pop-up includes a form, submitting the form could dismiss the pop-up.

Alignment



Do

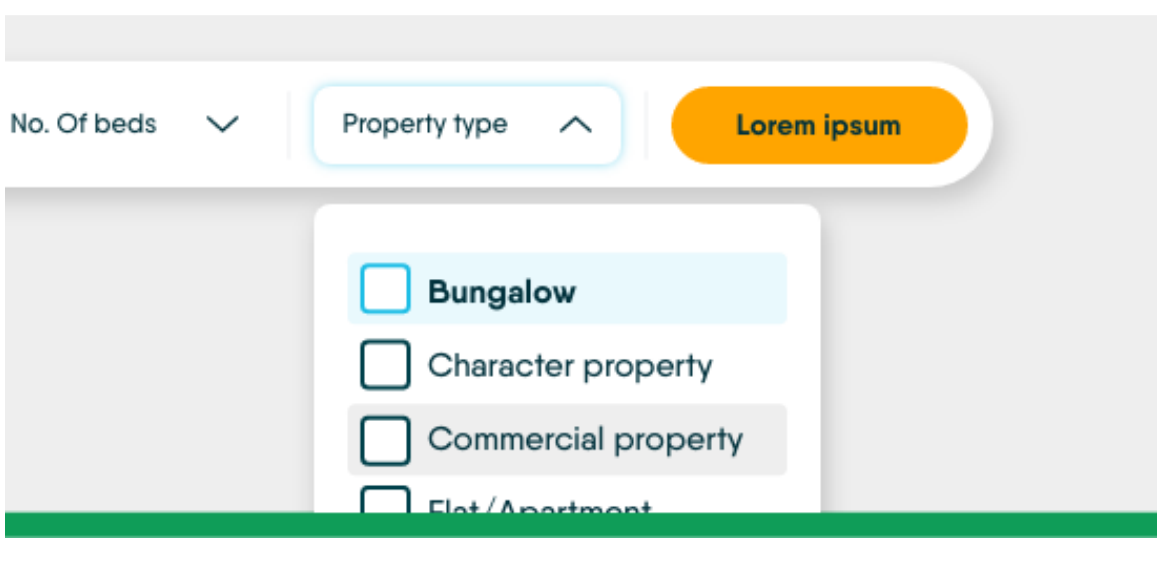
Align popover flush with UI trigger on at least one side.



Don't

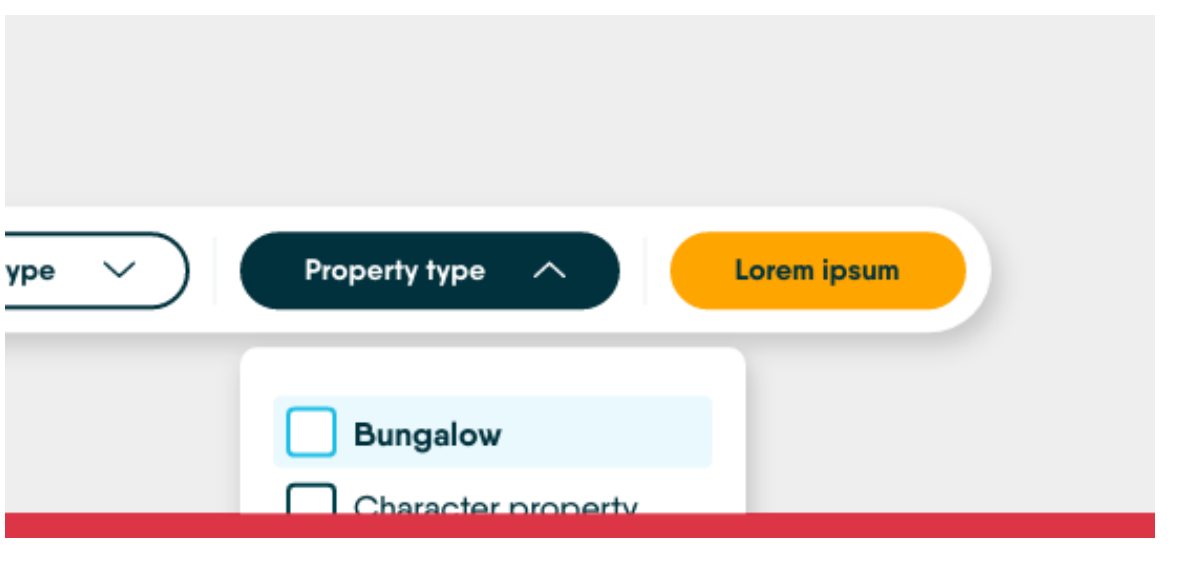
Don't arbitrarily place the popover around the UI trigger.

Behaviours


No. Of beds
Property type
Lorem ipsum
Bungalow
Character property
Commercial property
Flat/Apartment

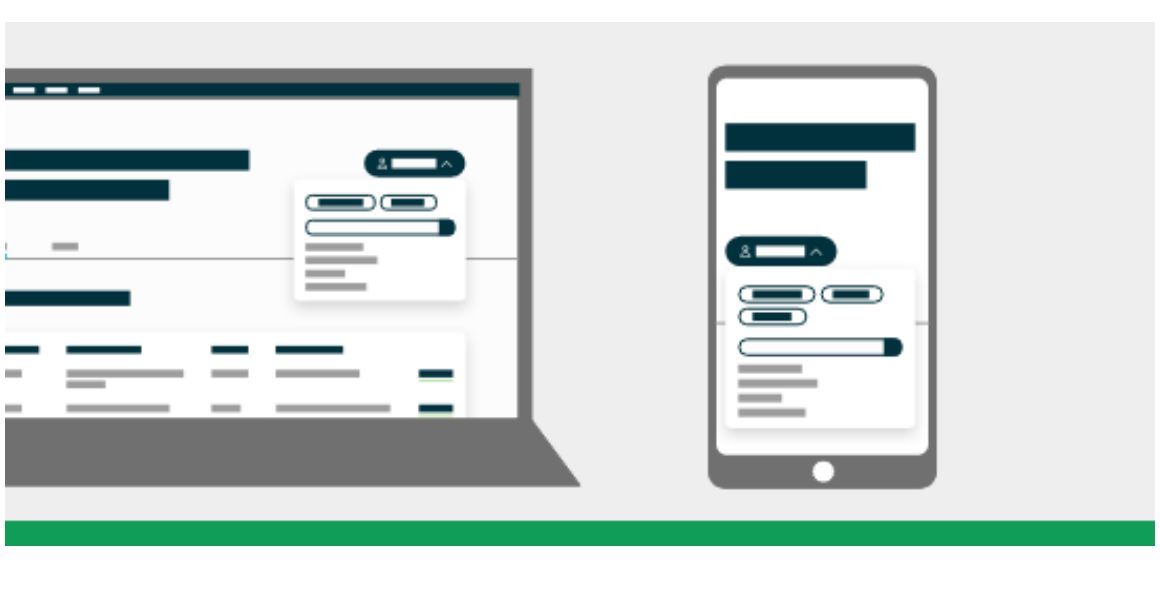
Do

Use selected and hover/focus states to distinguish elements in the popover and assist the user.


Property type
Lorem ipsum
Bungalow
Character property

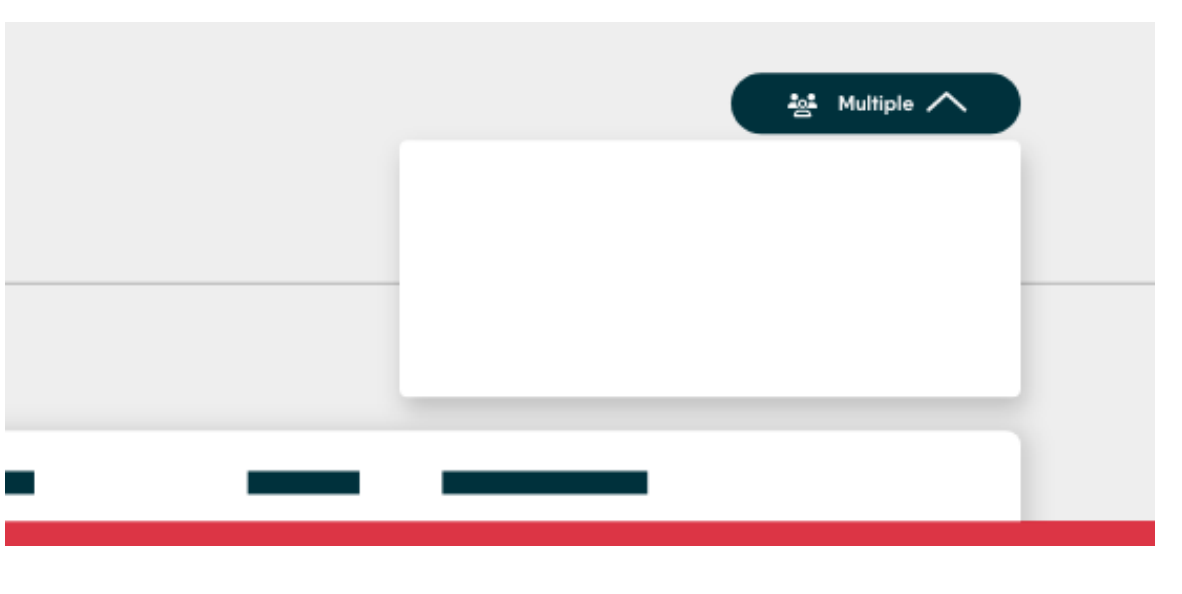
Don't

Over use the button component in one area - use alternative UI trigger styling styling where appropriate.



Do

Be mindful of how content in a popover will stack on mobile. Limit actions to be performed in a popover. If you require more extensive or complex user actions, consider using a component that disables the screen like a Modal.

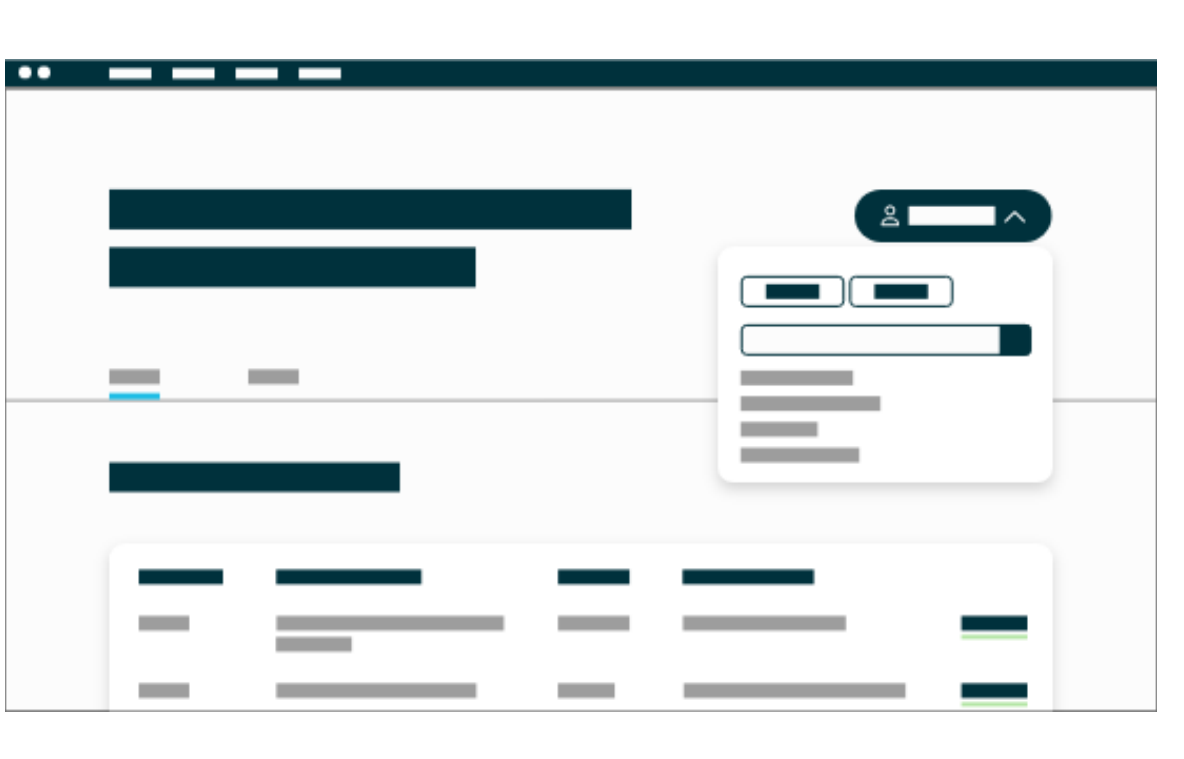


Don't

Have content with a higher position than the popover. The popover should over lay page content - with the exception of critical components like navigation.

Menu

Menus have a trigger button that has a visually defined down state or active state. They align with the trigger button and don't need a pointer to define their relationship to the trigger button. They are designed to be visually discreet and unobtrusive, allowing the main content and trigger element to remain prominent.

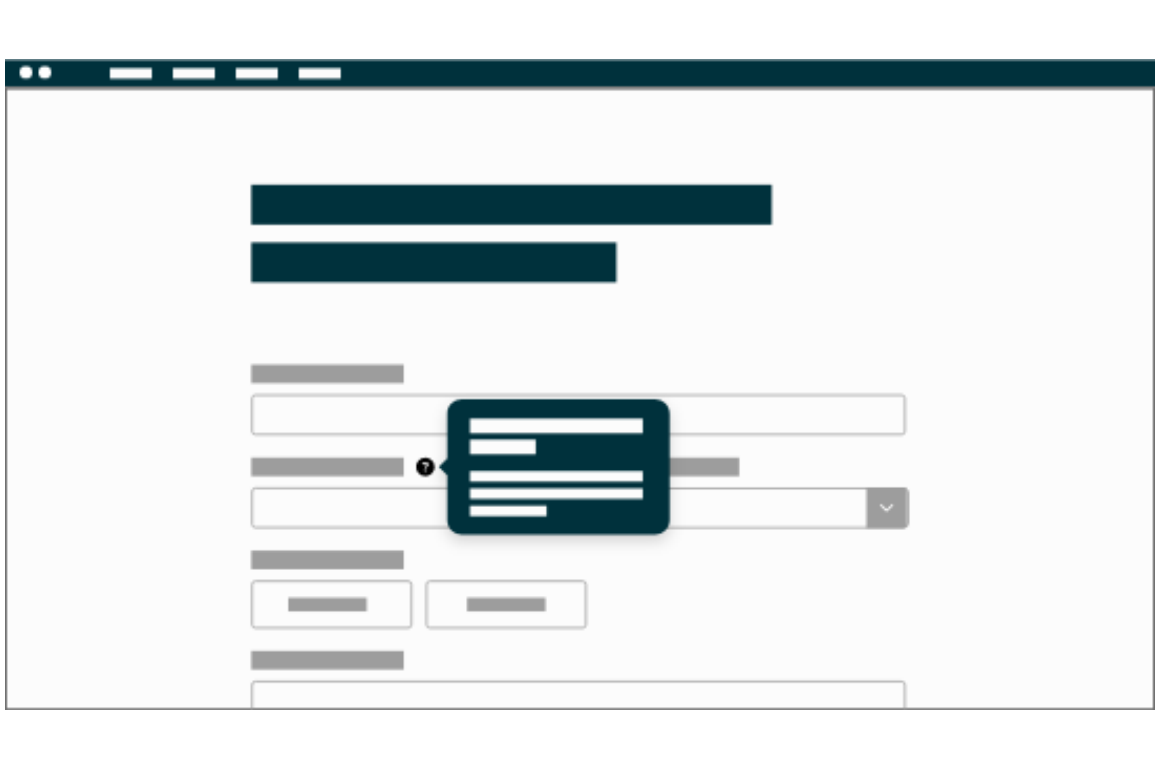


Menu amongst page content. Trigger button is prominent without distracting from main page content.

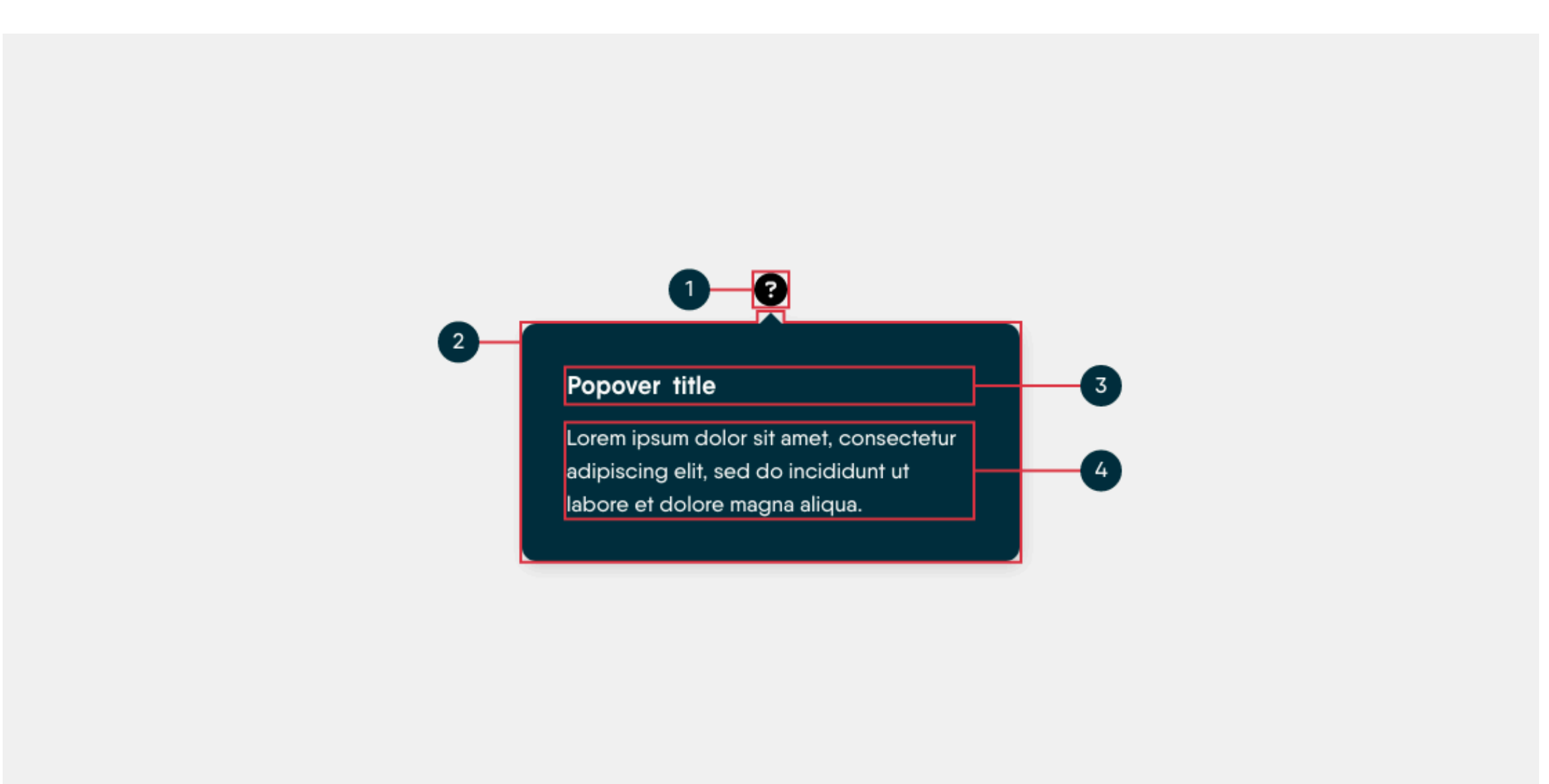
View menu component

Pointer

The pointer popover is visually attention-grabbing, with a pointer tip that visually indicates the association between the popover and its trigger. The trigger button is small and discreet, so as not to disrupt the content of the page.



Anatomy


1
2
3
4
Popover title
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit, sed do incididunt ut labore et dolore magna aliqua.

1. UI Trigger
2. Container with pointer tip
3. Title (lead text styles) (Optional)
4. Body: contains the content, could include text, links, icons, etc.

Trigger

Pointer popovers can be triggered in two of ways, depending on how it is built and its use case. Users can trigger the pop-up by either:

UI trigger: Clicking the UI trigger (button)
Hover: Hovering over the UI trigger (button)

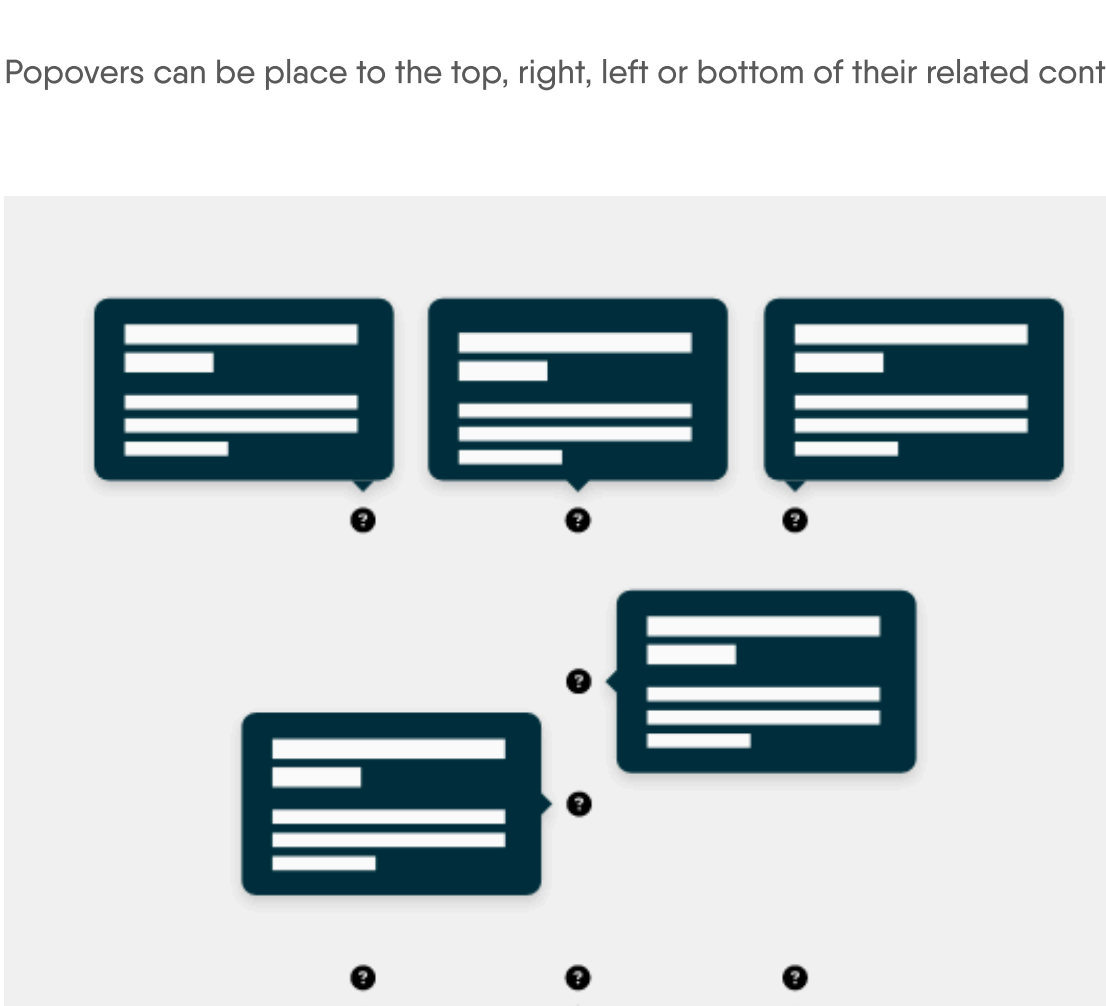
Dismissal

Pointer popovers can be dismissed in a variety of ways, depending on how it is built and its use case.

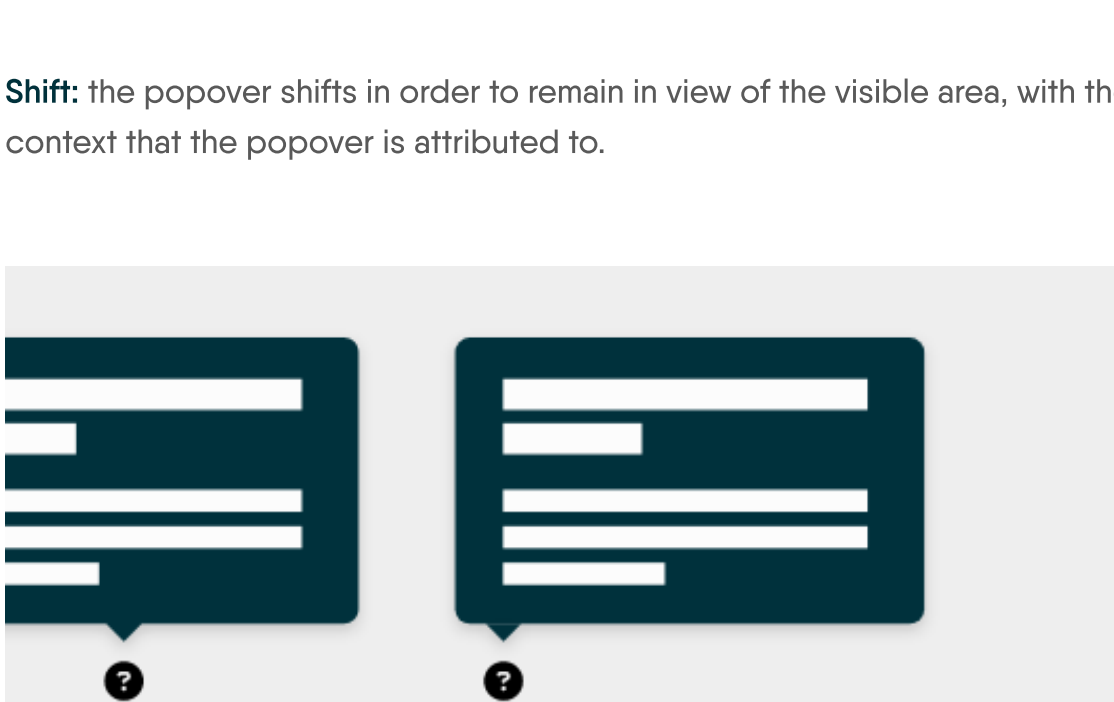
UI trigger: Clicking the UI trigger (button)
Mouse leave: Moving the mouse away from the popover container
Scroll depth: Scrolling more than a specified distance on screen
Scroll out of view: Scrolling the popover out of view
Outside Click: Clicking outside the pop-up area
Escape Key: Allowing users to dismiss the popover by pressing the escape (Esc) key is a common convention. This is especially useful for keyboard-centric users who prefer to navigate without using a mouse.
User Interaction: popovers may also be designed to be dismissed when users interact with specific elements within the pop-up. For example, if a pop-up includes a form, submitting the form could dismiss the pop-up.

Alignment

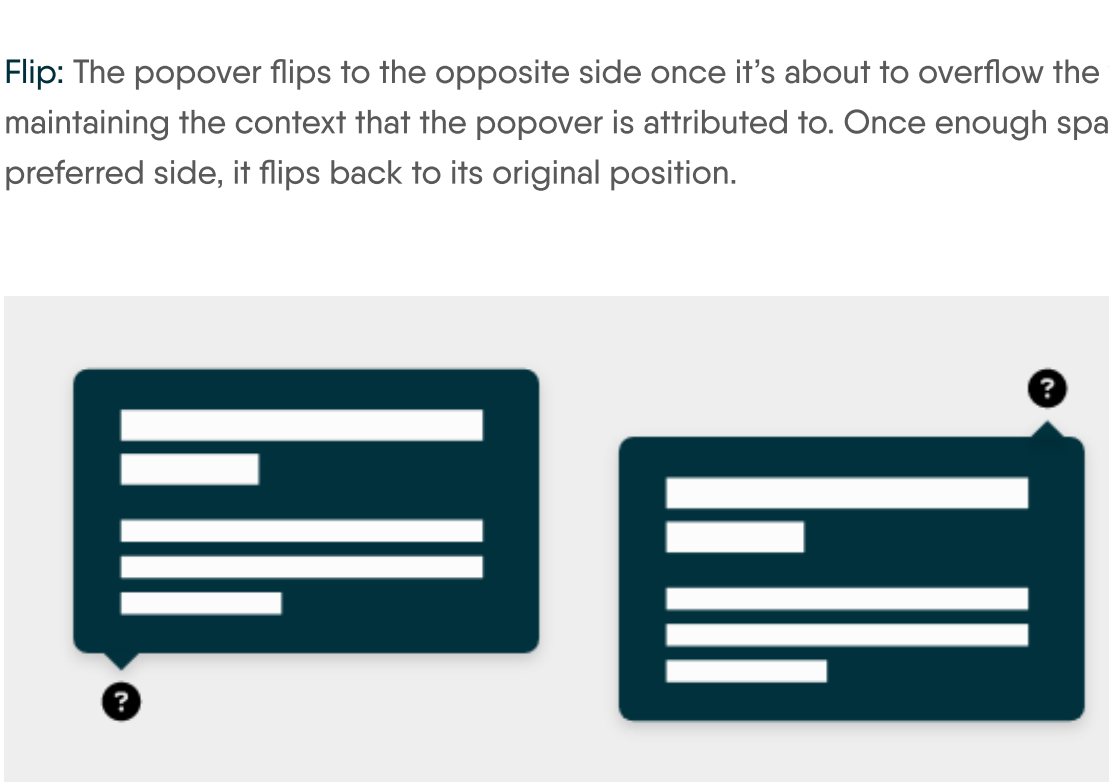
Popovers can be place to the top, right, left or bottom of their related content.

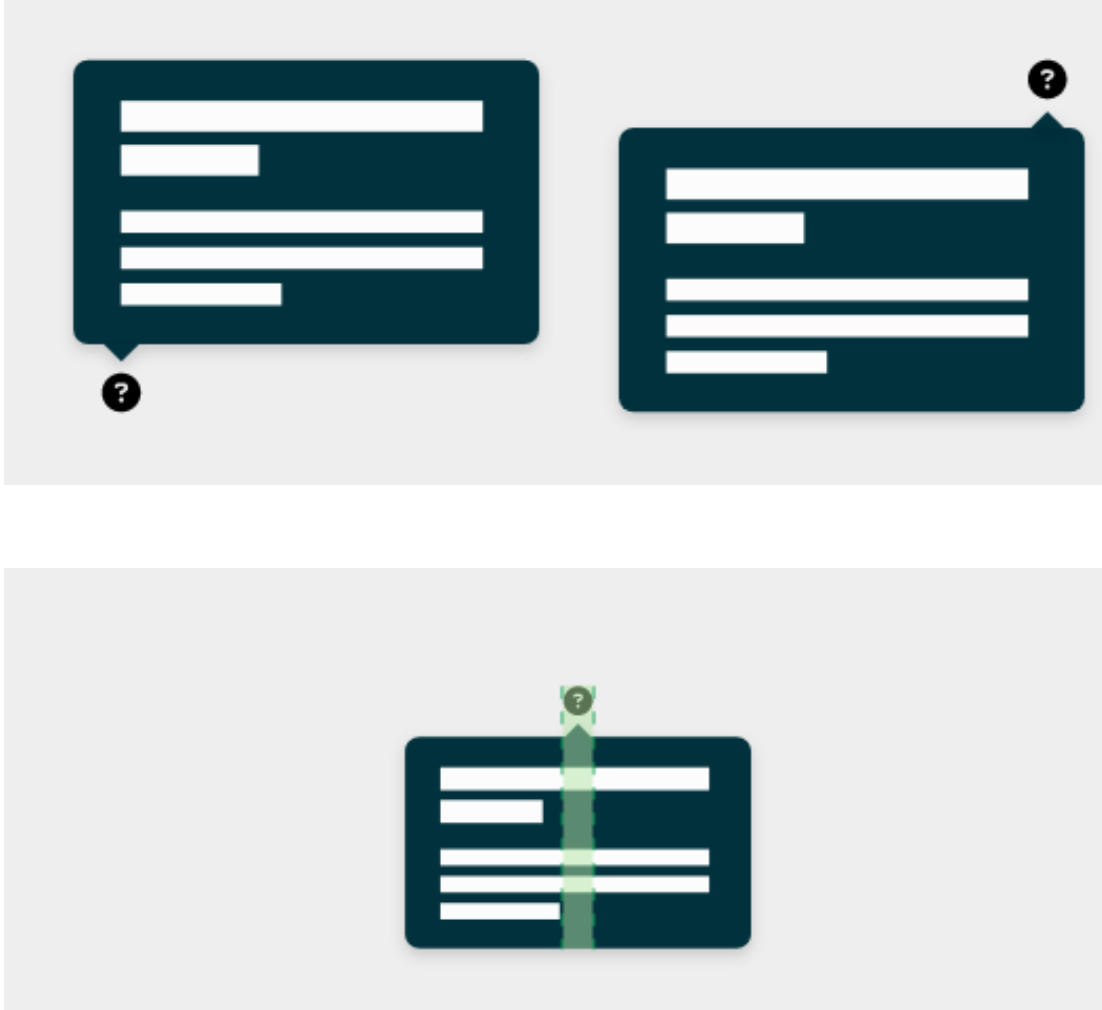


Shift: the popover shifts in order to remain in view of the visible area, with the pointer maintaining the context that the popover is attributed to.



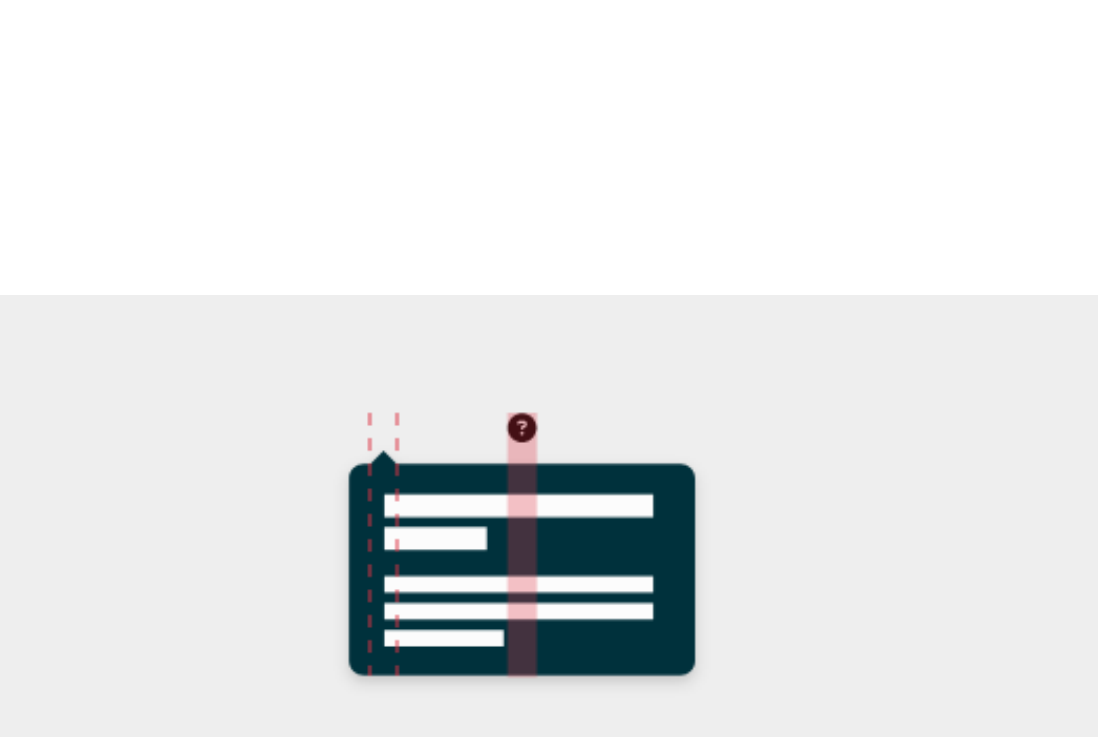
Flip: The popover flips to the opposite side once it's about to overflow the visible area, with the pointer maintaining the context that the popover is attributed to. Once enough space is detected on its preferred side, it flips back to its original position.





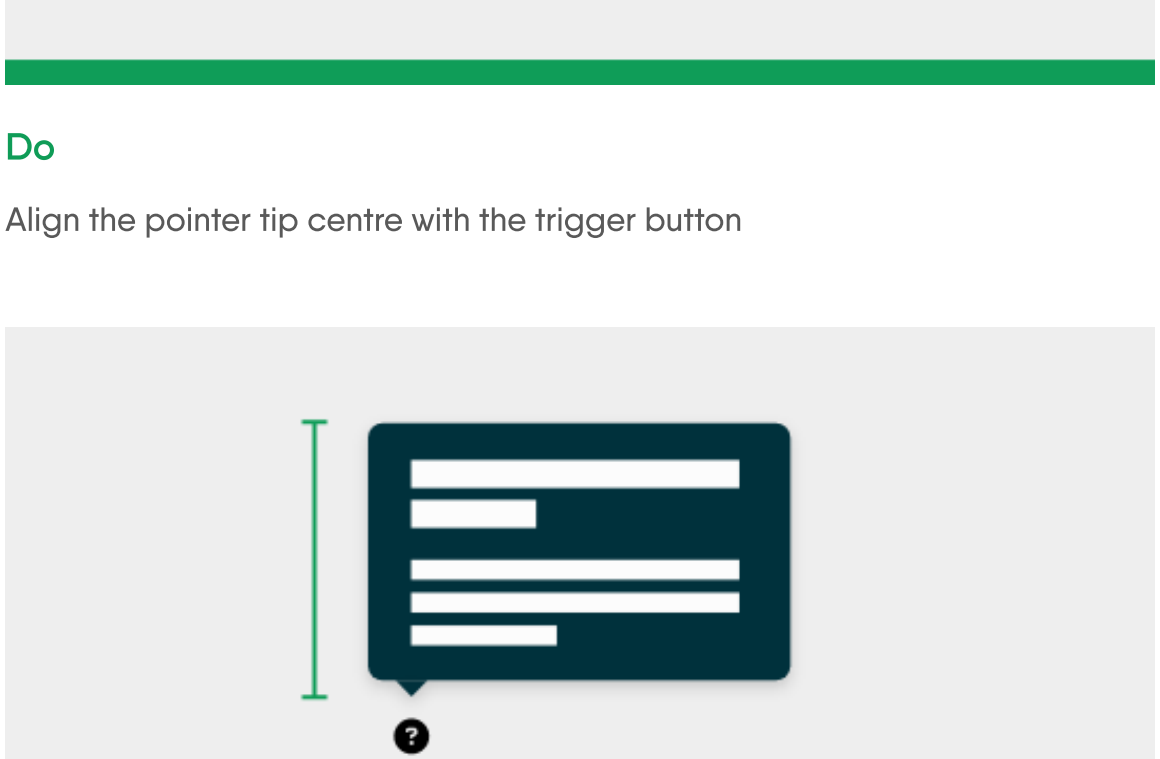
Do

Align the pointer tip centre with the trigger button



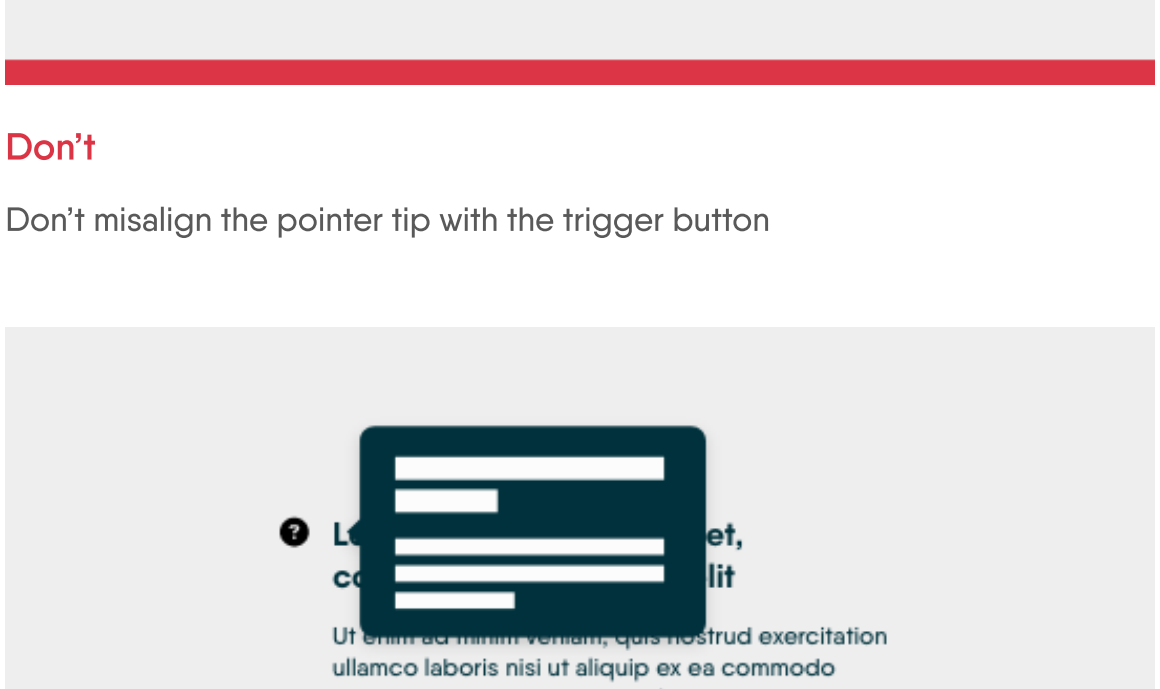
Don't

Don't misalign the pointer tip with the trigger button



Do

Make popovers short and to the point. Avoid large chunks of text in popovers. Too much text can cause cognitive overload, and users with smaller screens or who are zoomed in can lose visibility.



Don't

Avoid covering the element that the popover is attributed to, as it will lose its context.

Version control:	Date of design update:	Notable updates:
V1.6 added	06.08.2025	• Updated the dimensions to align with behaviour for menus • Replaced list item popover with link to the new menus component • Added new trigger and dismiss behaviour for pointer
V1.5 added	31.08.2023	Adding 'Popover Lists' to the document under 'No Tip' popovers.